

U1L17SP — Text Supplement

Two Private Arguments

Close-reading anchors from *Macbeth* and *Julius Caesar*

How to use this supplement

You may use **anything accurate from either play**. The passages below are lines worth focusing on, not limits on your evidence. Quote exact words when they are printed here. You may accurately paraphrase other events you remember from watching the plays. Do not invent quotations from memory.

Passage 1: *Macbeth*, Act 1, Scene 7 — *Macbeth* Before the Murder

Context: Duncan is Macbeth's king, kinsman, and guest. Alone, Macbeth considers consequences, duties, Duncan's character, and what drives his own intent before Lady Macbeth returns.

Macbeth: If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well
It were done quickly: if the assassination
Could trammel up the consequence, and catch
With his surcease success; that but this blow
Might be the be-all and the end-all here,
But here, upon this bank and shoal of time,
We'd jump the life to come. But in these cases
We still have judgment here; that we but teach
Bloody instructions, which, being taught, return
To plague the inventor.
He's here in double trust;
First, as I am his kinsman and his subject,
Strong both against the deed; then, as his host,
Who should against his murderer shut the door,
Not bear the knife myself.
Besides, this Duncan
Hath borne his faculties so meek, hath been
So clear in his great office, that his virtues
Will plead like angels, trumpet-tongued, against
The deep damnation of his taking-off.
I have no spur
To prick the sides of my intent, but only
Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself
And falls on the other.

Words in context

- **trammel up:** contain; **surcease:** death; **jump:** risk;
- **judgment here:** consequences or justice in this life; **double trust:** multiple obligations;
- **faculties:** powers and duties of office; **taking-off:** killing; **spur:** motive that drives action.

Passage 2: Julius Caesar, Act 2, Scene 1 — Brutus in the Orchard

Context: Alone before joining the conspiracy, Brutus considers Caesar's possible future power. He says he has no personal cause against Caesar and has not known Caesar's passions to overpower his reason.

Brutus: It must be by his death: and for my part,
I know no personal cause to spurn at him,
But for the general. He would be crown'd:
How that might change his nature, there's the question.
It is the bright day that brings forth the adder;
And that craves wary walking. Crown him? That;
And then, I grant, we put a sting in him,
That at his will he may do danger with.
The abuse of greatness is, when it disjoins
Remorse from power: and, to speak truth of Caesar,
I have not known when his affections sway'd
More than his reason. But 'tis a common proof,
That lowliness is young ambition's ladder,
Whereto the climber-upward turns his face;
But when he once attains the upmost round,
He then unto the ladder turns his back.
So Caesar may.
Then, lest he may, prevent. And, since the quarrel
Will bear no colour for the thing he is,
Fashion it thus; that what he is, augmented,
Would run to these and these extremities:
And therefore think him as a serpent's egg
Which, hatch'd, would, as his kind, grow mischievous,
And kill him in the shell.

Words in context

- **for the general:** for the public good; **remorse:** pity or restraint;
- **affections:** passions or desires; **common proof:** common experience;
- **prevent:** act beforehand; **colour:** plausible justification;
- **augmented:** increased in power; **mischievous:** harmful.

Broader evidence and fair comparison

You may test either private argument against later conduct and consequences. For Macbeth, possible reminders include Lady Macbeth's pressure, Duncan's murder, further violence, the apparitions, and Macbeth's final choices. For Brutus, possibilities include the forged letters, the assassination, his funeral defense, the civil war, and his later judgments. These are optional reminders, not diagnoses.

A character may admit some truth and still reason dishonestly elsewhere. A mistaken prediction is not automatically self-deception. Explain what each man knows, wants, assumes, and does with contrary pressure before comparing them.